Lachi Singh

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development Economics, Environmental Economics, Labour Economics

EDUCATION

London School of Economics, London, UK
PhD in Economics — *2022 - Expected 2027*
MRes in Economics (with Distinction) — *2020 - 2022*

Yale University, New Haven, CT — *2017 - 2018*
Master of Arts in International and Development Economics — *GPA: 3.875/4.000*

Miranda House, University of Delhi, New Delhi, India — *2014 - 2017*
Bachelor of Arts in Economics (Hons.) — Percentage: 85.68%

REFERENCES

Stephen Machin — *Professor of Economics, Director of CEP, LSE*
s.j.machin@lse.ac.uk

Swati Dhingra — *Associate Professor of Economics, LSE*
s.dhingra@lse.ac.uk

Sir Timothy Besley — *School Professor of Economics and Political Science, LSE*
t.besley@lse.ac.uk

WORKING PAPERS

1. **The Spatial Cost of Formality: Street Vendors' Preferences in India**
   with Muskan Jain — Job Market Paper

   Abstract: Formalisation policies in developing countries have proven hard to get right, and how much they achieve is sensitive to policy design. The problem is harder still for informal firms trading on public land, because a state cannot grant such a firm legal status without also deciding where it may trade. A large group of these firms is street vendors, who sell from carts, stalls and ground displays on streets and pavements and account for between 1.5 and 6.8 per cent of employment in low- and middle-income countries. States therefore offer them formality at a location rather than at a price, and deliver it through government-built vending zones that commonly stand empty. We price what relocation costs these firms, using a stated-preference experiment embedded in an original geolocated survey of 2,922 street vendors across 206 marketplaces in Patna, India, where the Street Vendors Act of 2014 makes certification free and attaches the protected spot to a location instead. Vendors value formality: at an unchanged commute the average vendor would pay up to 4.5 per cent of monthly sales for a zone, and 68 per cent accept one when the spot is free. Distance then consumes that value, and unevenly. The acceptable rent falls to 2.1 per cent of sales one kilometre further out and to nothing at about 3.8 kilometres, with more than half the value going in the first kilometre alone. Rent and information shift take-up less than distance does over the moves a zone is likely to require. Zones sit empty not because the state has failed to offer formality or because vendors do not want it, but because conferring it requires moving the firm, and moving it costs most of what it is worth.

2. **Embedded Livelihoods: The Structure of Street Vending Markets in India**
   with Muskan Jain
   IGC Outputs (Working Paper, Policy Brief), British Academy Exhibition (Slides)

Abstract: Street vending provides livelihoods for millions of workers across the developing world, yet the sector remains poorly understood and subject to repeated policy interventions that have largely failed. This paper provides a comprehensive microeconomic profile of street vending markets in Patna, Bihar, using original survey data from 2,922 stationary vendors across 206 marketplaces. We document that vendors are deeply embedded in overlapping social, spatial, and economic structures that make their livelihoods far more organized and far harder to administratively reshape than standard policy frameworks assume. Entry into vending and product choice are mediated by family networks; labour is almost entirely household-based; procurement is organized through stable relational ties with suppliers; and vendors cluster in spatially differentiated markets from which they derive substantial agglomeration economies. Pricing is implicitly coordinated through shared wholesale cost anchors, and 99 percent of vendors have never changed their marketplace despite operating without legal tenure and facing regular eviction pressure. The regulatory environment compounds this vulnerability: fewer than 2 percent of vendors are aware of the Street Vendors Act of 2014, which was designed to protect them, and over 40 percent report moderate to high psychological distress. We argue that the concept of embeddedness offers a more accurate framework for understanding this sector than the atomistic agent model implicit in most policy interventions, and that formalization efforts, particularly spatial relocation mandates, will continue to fail until they account for the social, spatial, and economic complementarities that sustain vendor livelihoods.

RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

1. **Making Green Transition Work: Adoption of Electric Vehicles in India**
with Linchuan Xu

Abstract: While electric vehicle (EV) adoption has surged in developed countries, far less is known about how this green transition will unfold in the Global South. Against the backdrop of rapid industrialization and motorization, developing countries will soon become the primary carbon emitters for the next generation. Facilitating EV transition may therefore become the most crucial lever to reach the right balance between economic growth and reducing emissions. This project will provide the first in-depth documentation of EV transition in India over the last decade and discuss how to make green transition work in developing economies. Transport accounts for around 14% of energy-related CO2 emissions in India and is one of the fastest-growing emissions sectors. EV adoption is now central to India's Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and Low-Emission Development Strategy (LEDS). India is also one of the first developing countries to launch policies such as FAME (Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of Electric Vehicles) to speed up EV uptake, yet progress has been uneven across states and vehicle segments. Absence of systematic data and empirical analysis has left open questions about the effectiveness of EV policies and their heterogeneities. This project will build a novel comprehensive dataset combining vehicle registrations, state and national policies, charging infrastructure, and congestion and local air pollution data. We will answer three interrelated questions: (1) What is the status of EV adoption in India, and how does it vary spatially and by vehicle segments? (2) How effective have subsidies and other policies been in driving uptake? (3) Through a general equilibrium framework, we explore what combinations of policies—like congestion pricing or targeted subsidies—can accelerate adoption and generate environmental benefits most cost-effectively? With reduced-form regression-analysis and quantitative modelling, we identify the main barriers and the right incentives to scale up green transition in the developing world.

2. **Weathering the Waste: Inventory Choice, Market Aggregation and Food Loss Among Urban Street Vendors** *with Swati Dhingra*

Abstract: Do decentralized markets efficiently aggregate supply decisions when firms must commit inventory under correlated uncertainty? We study street vendors selling perishable produce in Patna, India, who first commit to inventory at wholesale markets then set retail prices during the trading day. Demand uncertainty is driven by weather and marketplace-day footfall affect-

ing all vendors simultaneously. Waste from spoilage provides a direct measure of costly supply mistakes. We develop a two-stage model identifying three inefficiency channels: business-stealing through prices, availability externalities through stockout spillovers, and coordination failure under correlated shocks. We show correlated uncertainty amplifies competitive inefficiency: safety-stock wedges scale with total uncertainty, and common shocks create non-diversifiable market volatility. Our empirical strategy combines vendor-level panel data with randomized price experiments. We test whether vendors optimize individually and whether markets achieve efficient aggregation, classifying behaviour into scenarios based on individual versus market efficiency. The analysis will establish whether inefficiency arises from individual mistakes (learning errors, biases) or market failures (strategic competition, coordination), a distinction critical for policy, since if markets exhibit individual efficiency with market inefficiency, improving individual forecasting cannot address strategic externalities. The findings inform intervention design in committed-supply markets facing growing demand volatility from climate change.

3. **Exposure to Pollution, Productivity and Well-Being: Street Vending Sector in India**

   Abstract: Street vendors constitute a significant portion of the informal workforce in low- and middle-income countries. They operate in public spaces that are often marked by inadequate sanitation, high noise levels, and air pollution. Prolonged exposure to such unfavourable working conditions can adversely affect both worker productivity and physical and mental health. Focusing on a city in India, this project aims to gather comprehensive data on marketplace/workplace characteristics including physical environment features like local pollution, as well as vendor characteristics. The goal is to understand the role of street vendors in well-being of city residents and explore potential policy solutions to enhance their working conditions and better integrate them into the urban landscape.

4. **From Street to Screen: Digital Marketplaces and the Informal Economy**

RESEARCH GRANTS

Current total: £175,299

◇ CEP PhD Grant (£1,000) *2026*
◇ IGC Grant (£19,999) *with Swati Dhingra* *2025*
◇ IGC Small Grants (£8,015) *with Linchuan Xu* *2025*
◇ Global Sustainability Research Fund (£89,628) *with Swati Dhingra* *2025*
◇ Hub of Equal Representation (HER) Grant, STICERD (£10,000) *2025*
◇ LSE Seed Research Fund (£19,800) *with Swati Dhingra & Muskan Jain* *2025*
◇ British Academy (£10,000) *with Swati Dhingra & Muskan Jain* *2024*
◇ IGC Small Grants (£16,857) *with Muskan Jain* *2024*

AWARDS

◇ LSE Department of Economics Teaching Bonus Award *2022, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026*
◇ LSE Economics PhD Scholarship *2020-2025*
◇ Undergraduate Academic Award for Excellence *2017*

RESEARCH ASSISTANTSHIPS

London School of Economics, London, UK
Part-Time Research Assistant for Prof. Gilat Levy & Prof. Ronny Razin *2022 - 2024*

Yale University, New Haven, CT *2018 - 2020*
Full-Time Research Assistant at Tobin Center for Economic Policy for Prof. Zack Cooper

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

London School of Economics, London, UK
Course Manager and Teacher for EC1B5: Macroeconomics I *2023-26*

Teaching Fellow for EC402: Econometrics *2023-25*
TA for EC400: Introductory Course in Mathematics and Statistics *2023-25*
TA for EC2C1: Econometrics II *2022-23*
TA for EC220: Introduction to Econometrics *2021-22*

CONFERENCES AND PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

Royal Economic Society Annual Conference, Newcastle, UK *July 2026*
British Academy Ideas Festival, London, UK *June 2026*
Third Development Economics Workshop, Durham, UK *June 2026*
Evidence to Action: Environment Sustainability and Urban Futures in India, Patna, India *May 2026*

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE AND SKILLS

Referee: Economica

Affiliations: STICERD; LSE Economics of Environment and Energy Programme (EEE); Center for Economic Performance (CEP); Global Action for Policy (GAP) Initiative, Northeastern University

Programming Languages and Frameworks: Stata, Python, SQL (PostGreSQL), LaTeX, SurveyCTO (ODK), Git

Languages: English (Native), Hindi (Native), French (Beginner)

Last Updated on November 6, 2026